Statement

Sensitive

Statement in the matter of R v Vida Reid

Name	Danica Rochelle Hall
Occupation	Assessment and Referral Officer
Address	Known to National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS)
Date	14 October 2022

STATES:

1. This statement made by me accurately sets out the evidence that I would be prepared, if necessary, to give in court as a witness.

2. My full name is Danica Rochelle Hall. I am 31 years of age.

3. My residential address is known to the National Disability Insurance Scheme.

4. Forward Focused Group (FFG) (ABN 98 643 878 639) is owned and operated by a married couple, named Vida and Simon Reid.

5. I first started at FFG in December 2021 as an Accounts Officer. I was brought into the role with very limited experience in the NDIS and no qualifications or training in accounting.

6. When I was employed by FFG, Vida and Simon were in partnership with Rejaul Alam, who was the Accounts Manager with FFG and The Hive and later promoted to the Chief Financial Officer (CFO). Rejaul started in October 2021 and became a financial partner in December 2021. He was promoted to CFO January-February 2022.

7. In addition to this, Rejaul was also in the process of starting a Plan Management company called Exact Financial Solutions (ABN 50 656 716 497). This was to be run by Rejaul.



..... Signature

D H ..... Witness

8. FFG hired people with little knowledge and understanding of the NDIS and limited relevant qualifications. The few staff that have been employed with experience and qualifications, didn't last very long in their employment.

9. A good example of this was Jen Nuttal who was employed as FFG's Operations Manager. She was there for approximately nine weeks, before being fired on 29 June 2022.

10. Although coming in on an extremely low wage, I was just glad to have a job in what at first appeared to be with an exciting, growing, fun company. However, things started to come to light when early on in my employment (just a couple of weeks in), three staff were fired/resigned all on the same day. They were Grant and Melissa Williams and Toby whose last name I don't recall. Since I started my employment with FFG, I saw 24 staff leave namely: -

- Grant Williams (fired – 16.12.2021).
- Toby (resigned – 16.12.2021).
- Melissa Williams (resigned but would have been fired – 16.12.2021).
- Emma Imani.
- Rachael Thomas (resigned).
- Shadi Norouzi (resigned).
- Rebecca Bowers (resigned, but would have been fired – 08.3.2022).
- Hassan Zia (resigned – 16.03.2022, after two days).
- Nakita Toia (resigned – 28.03.2022).
- Elanor Smith (resigned – 29.03.2022).
- Sally See (resigned – 05.04.2022).
- Jaimi Lee Smith (fired – 06.04.2022).
- Roshni Kaur (resigned – 26.04.2022).
- Cori whose surname I don't know (resigned – 26.04.2022, after 3 days).
- Brodie Hall (resigned – 06.05.2022).

- Ally Oleksiuk (did resign but was rehired after I left the business as Vida's personal assistant).
- Blesson Varghese (resigned – 23.06.2022).
- Jan Nuttal (fired – 29.06.2022).
- Louise Ireland (resigned).
- Tanya Gukwa (resigned – 05.07.2022).
- Nassam whose surname I don't know (resigned – 05.07.2022, after one week).
- Brooke whose surname I don't know (fired – 11.07.2022).
- Sarah King (resigned – 15.07.2022).
- Jodie Salmon (resigned – 15.07.2022).

11. The personnel that were fired were all in their six-month probationary period.

12. Most of these people left without any explanation, leaving the remaining staff to work out that they've left or find out from another employees. On a few occasions, we were informed, but with most of those, the person has been spoken about negatively by Vida. The high turnover of staff alone is an indication of the kind of company FFG was while I was there.

13. Another red flag was the New Year's cruise. Something didn't quite add up, but I put it down to my lack of knowledge of the NDIS, however when I heard that we were charging $7,500 per person, something didn't sound right. I wasn't too involved with this as I was still fairly new and it didn't make sense to me so I left it to the other Accounts Officer, Virginie Fanny-Dulloo, to handle it while I focused on the other parts of my role.

14. I was still aware of what was happening and the conversations occurring in the office. Support Coordinators were asked on several occasions by Vida to just 'call all of the Participants' to see who wanted to go on the cruise, even though Participants had already been asked before and declined. When these Participants had been called about the cruise, they had all been charged with 15 minutes of support coordination.

15. Participants didn't seem to want to use $7,500 of their plan on a one-night event so Vida and Rejaul were scrambling to get numbers and were pressuring staff to harass Participants into coming.

16. Following a two week break over Christmas, I returned, and this was when I started to see things a lot more clearly. With the number of staff coming and going and then seeing and hearing certain conversations and behaviours, I started to see that while most of us were in this job for the Participants, the people running these companies were just there to make money and weren't there to support the Participants. As it was, Vida and Simon were both coming home with a $140,000 salary each per annum and Rejaul was on $100,000 per annum. As I was in accounts, I had visibility of everyone's wages.

17. I've seen Participants get discarded once FFG could no longer inappropriately invoice against their plans. These Participants included Andrew Hahn, Madeline Robinson, Suzanne Shepherd, Alexsis Bott, Corina Abraham and Sarah-Jane Clulow.

18. While Rejaul was appointed as the CFO, he didn't appear to be qualified for that role based on his knowledge of accounting. I had visibility of the invoicing in Xero which is a business accounting program. I saw numerous invoices in Xero that had been created and sent by Rejaul that had no evidence to support that those line items had been delivered to Participants.

19. Rejaul lied to me on several occasions about invoices that he had sent or had asked us to send. For example, in relation to Participant Susan Shepherd, he lied about the amount of cleaning services that were provided. There were unreasonable and inflated hours charged given her circumstances which were also not supported by the billing of the service provider.

20. I have seen complete misuse of NDIS funding and financial abuse in that due to overcharging, there have been Participants left with no funding to use on services that they actually need.

21. False information is being provided to the NDIS in order for Participants to get new plans so that FFG/The Hive can then take the remaining funding from their previous expired plans. An example of this is Meghan Goodwin (NDIS number 431576199) who has had seven NDIS Plans since May last year. The following are the dates of these plans:

- 19/05/2021 - 19/05/2022.
- 26/05/2021 - 26/05/2022.
- 15/10/2021 - 15/10/2023.
- 01/12/2021 - 01/12/2023.
- 02/12/2021 - 02/12/2023.
- 13/12/2021 - 03/12/2023.
- 04/04/2022 - 03/04/2024 (of which over $45,000 from Core had already been used in just over 3 months).

22. Meghan Goodwin is also a perfect example of where weekly invoices of up to $6,500 were sent and paid for services that were not provided. I knew this as I had visibility of Xero and BrightHR which was the human resources and rostering system.

23. Another example of claiming from expired plans is Participant Yvonne Harrison (NDIS number 431664181). Yvonne got a new plan which left round $40,000 remaining in her previous expired plan. Around $30,000 of that was then invoiced through The Hive and sent to the Plan Manager, Reserve Wealth. This was disputed by Reserve Wealth as the services weren't provided, and the invoices had been back dated to before Yvonne was even a Participant at FFG.

24. The invoices relating to Yvonne went back to March 2021 even though Yvonne only became a FFG Participant on 17 November 2021. The Hive was only registered as a business in August 2021 and the invoices were dated March 2021 which was approximately five months before they were registered as a company.

25. After the Plan Manager Reserve Wealth disputed the invoices, most of the invoices were voided and only the invoices from November 2021 onwards were paid even though these supports had not been provided.

26. Yvonne only started using support workers from The Hive from March 2022, and only for a few hours a week. Yvonne was then convinced to change Plan Managers to a business called Assist Plan Managers and similar invoices to those that had been voided, for similar amounts and with service dates going back to early 2021, were again sent to Assist Plan Managers. These invoices related to services apparently provided under her expired plan but still before she was a Participant under FFG or The Hive.

27. I have provided other examples of financial abuse to the NDIS Quality and Safeguards Commission.

28. Andrew Hahn (NDIS number 431173013) was a Participant living in the Safety Bay house which was accommodation used by FFG to provide Supported Independent Living (SIL).

29. I became aware of certain email correspondence from Andy and his advocate Joshua Davidson, where they questioned the provision of support workers to Andy. I saw this email correspondence in a shared account with the FFG accounts department. Andy had indicated that he hadn't used any support worker and his advocate had also requested evidence of the support worker services being provided to Andy. Andy has since been evicted from the property and is no longer a Participant of FFG or The Hive.

30. On 20 July 2022, Vida forwarded an email to the shared Accounts inbox that she had sent to Andy's Plan Manager, NDSP, on 14 July 2022. In this email, Vida mentions that Andy stayed rent free in the Safety Bay SIL house. I know that Andy paid his board and lodging for SIL accommodation fortnightly via Centrepay as I had visibility on these payments through Xero. Vida also stated in this email that Andy demanded support staff tend to him around the clock and even after hours. Andy received no Support Workers during his time with FFG or The Hive as there were no time sheets

recorded by support workers. I know this as I had access to the rosters and timesheets through BrightHR to generate invoices.

31. Regarding Participant Angelus Regali-Park (NDIS 431035309) I have an email from his Plan Manager, Manage Mode where they were querying an invoice as they believed those services had not been provided.

32. Regarding Participant Bassam Haidar (NDIS number 431524488), as of 14 April 2022, in his expired plan, he had $4,752.80 remaining in Capacity Building - Improved Daily Living Skills and $54,729.57 remaining in Core - Assistance with Daily Life. I made sure I got a screenshot of his budget through the plan manager portal as Bassam had just gotten a new plan. I overheard Vida planning with Rejaul to invoice this remaining amount from his expired plan after she established how much funding was left in the expired plan.

33. I know that on 13 April 2022, there were invoices sent to NDSP who were Bassam's plan managers. I knew this because I had checked in Xero. These false invoices were sent by Rejaul under the direction of Vida. These invoices were as follows: -

- Invoice from FFG for $4,655.76 for counselling. I know these services were not provided as there was no evidence in Care View which was our customer records management (CRM) system.
- Eight invoices from The Hive totalling $54,254.92 for House cleaning and Support Work. I know these services were not provided as there was evidence in BrightHR.

34. Janine Craig (NDIS number 431081450) was a Participant under FFG and had never been looked after under The Hive until around July 2022. I know from Xero that there were 14 invoices totalling $40,947.20 that were sent to her plan manager. This was against funding remaining in her expired plan. There was no evidence in BrightHR to support her receiving any services from the Hive for the dates invoiced.

35. Meghan Goodwin (NDIS 431576199) was another Participant who was living in the Safety Bay SIL accommodation up until about August 2022.

36. In a meeting with Vida and Accounts, Vida told us she was going to get Meghan's plan 'refreshed' in order to get more funding. This was after Meghan's funds had been exhausted by fraudulent invoicing. I know this because I had looked at her plan through the Plan Manager's portal and there was no evidence in BrightHR indicating that she had received support worker services.

37. I saw an email from Vida asking Accounts to charge Meghan for Short Term Accommodation (STA) from FFG while she was in a hotel for six nights. The email also said to charge 2:1 support through The Hive, even though STA includes Support Work. I had known Megan from some time as a client and I know she didn't require constant 2:1 support but did require 1:1 support on an ad hoc basis.

38. Seyed Yunus Hashimi (NDIS number 431174406) - This Participant went overseas from 21 March 2022 and stayed for several months. During this time, Yunus was still being charged for supports through FFG and The Hive. These charges were for the provision of Support Workers and he was being charged for the same services on the same date through both FFG and The Hive.

39. Being knew to the industry, it took me some time to learn about NDIS and the funding structure. I was being trained by Virginie who was the Accounts Officer originally with FFG and then went over to The Hive. I think it was about January 2022 that I realised that I was being trained incorrectly and to send false invoices to Plan Managers. Specifically, I was being trained to:

- Send invoices for services not provided,
- Send invoices to claim funds from expired plans for services not provided, and
- Alter dates on invoices to claim from a plans that had funding left in them.

40. I did start to begin questioning Virginie and sometimes Rejaul about some of the invoices and mentioned the lack of evidence that services were actually delivered.

41. In mid-March 2022, the responsibility of invoicing for certain Participants was taken out of my hands to be overseen by Rejaul. For example, if I questioned the validity of an invoice with Rejaul, he often told me not to worry about it and that he would

send the invoice himself. I could see that he had done this through Xero. My access to the Plan Managers portals was also removed. I was told only Rejaul had access to this information to see the funding levels for plan-managed Participants.

42. Earlier on in the year when I started to see what was happening, I had a short conversation with Virginie, where I told her I was uncomfortable invoicing for services that weren't being provided. Virginie just laughed and said, "I started out like that too, but you just learn to get over it and just do it". I didn't continue this conversation any further and have since never talked to Virginie about this.

43. There have also been instances where Vida, who is also a NDIS Participant (NDIS number 430970696), has charged Support Work from her plan to pay for personal expenses, such as work done on her house. I know she had some fencing work done at her home address as I saw an invoice come through from Modplex for this work. This was charged as support work from Vida's plan, as I received an email from The Hive's shared Accounts email address instructing me to invoice this fencing work through The Hive for support work under Vida's plan. I don't know exactly who sent this email, but I did as I was instructed. I felt uncomfortable doing this as it was incorrect.

44. Vida's son, Alexander Reid, is also a NDIS Participant (NDIS number 430972240,) and Alex's plan is also being used to pay for Support Workers for his sister Atrisa (Vida's daughter), who is not a NDIS Participant. I know this because I saw rosters and timesheets for support workers assigned to Atrisa. I processed these invoices through Alex's plan as directed by Rejaul.

45. Invoices had also been sent with staff members names on them even though services weren't provided. This included counselling invoices for Meghan Goodwin, where:

- Sally See's name was included on multiple invoices regarding the delivery of counselling services to her after Sally had left FFG on 5 April 2022. These services were not provided as there was no evidence in Careview which was FFG's CRM.

- Cori's name whose surname I don't recall was also used on invoices for Meghan. Cori was with the business for three days before she resigned. These services were not provided as there was no evidence in Careview.

46. More recently in about Jun-July 2022, Hazel Carbungco's name was used on invoices for counselling, despite not being registered as a counsellor under APHRA. The services in relation to these invoices were not provided as there was no evidence in Careview.

47. I resigned from FFG with my last day being Monday the 25 July 2022. I resigned because I did not feel comfortable doing what I was being asked to do by Vida and Rejaul. I was being asked to create and send false invoices particularly before March 2022. I also didn't like the culture of bullying in the business and how our Participants were being treated by company personnel. Once I started to question the practice of sending false invoices, Vida and Rejaul started asking other Accounts staff members to send those invoices.

48. This statement is true to the best of my knowledge and belief. I have made this statement knowing that, if it is tendered in evidence, I will be guilty of a crime if I have wilfully included in the statement anything that I know to be false or that I do not believe is true.

Signature _____
Danica Rochelle Hall

Statement taken and signature witnessed by me about 3.45pm on
14 October 2022 at Perth in Western Australia.

Signature _____
Gerard Righetti
Assistant Director – Fraud Investigations